

The Glorious King of Tantras of the Great Sky

Śrī Mahākha Tantra Rāja · Toh 387 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་ནམ་མཁའ་ཆེ་པའི་རྒྱ་ཀླིང་པོ།

The Glorious King of Tantras of the Great Sky, known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Mahākha Tantra Rāja and in Tibetan as Dpal Nam mkha' chen po'i rgyud kyi rgyal po, is a Buddhist tantric scripture belonging to the Kangyur, where it is catalogued as Toh 387. It is a tantra of the highest class, set within the visionary framework of the Blessed One dwelling in union with a vajra lady amid an assembly of heroes and ḍākinīs, a setting characteristic of Anuttarayoga or similar advanced tantric literature. The text opens with the bodhisattva Vajrahṛdaya posing a series of profound questions to the Buddha regarding what is subdued, what is possessed, and what constitutes the great fear, inviting a doctrinal exposition that unfolds in verse and prose. As its title suggests, the scripture is centrally concerned with the symbolism and realization of the great sky — an expression pointing to the vast, unobstructed nature of mind and reality as understood in Vajrayāna Buddhism.

In the language of India: Śrī Mahākha Tantra Rāja. In the language of Tibet:
The Glorious King of Tantras of the Great Sky.

Homage to Glorious Great Bliss.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, dwelt within the bhaga of the vajra lady of the body, speech, and mind of all tathāgatas. Likewise, he dwelt together with innumerable heroes and ḍākinīs. From among that assembly, the great bodhisattva Vajrahṛdaya circumambulated the Blessed One three times to the right, made outer, inner, and secret offerings, and then spoke these words:

O wonder! O Blessed One, greatly to be feared,
What is subdued, and what does one possess?
What is the fear, and what is the great one?
I pray that you, O Lord, explain this to me.

The Blessed One then declared:

What is subdued are the four māras,
each of which in turn has four aspects,
making sixteen in all — know this as their number.
The antidote to each now follows.

First, the four māras of the vase empowerment:
through mistaken conceptuality regarding color and form,
the many apprehended and apprehender phenomena that arise
are renowned as the māra of the aggregates.

Attachment, aversion, and the rest
are the māra of the afflictions.

A teacher without a genuine guide who shows the true path,
one who instead produces causes and shows paths
that give rise to aversion and enmity —
such a one is the māra of the son of the gods.

The cutting of life through the force
of karma and mental afflictions
is the māra of the lord of death.

By dwelling well in the generation stage,
the māra of the son of the gods is overcome.

The conceptuality of the many wrong conceptions is cut.

Thus the māra of the aggregates is vanquished.

By the equal taste of dependent support and what depends upon it,
the māra of the afflictions is vanquished.

Untimely death and the exhaustion of one's life span —
these are the māras of death.

Through the sage's power over life span,
lasting even a thousand years and beyond,
the māra of the lord of death in the form of life is vanquished.

Moreover, a further specific way to vanquish māra
is to draw in the external vital essence of life.

When accomplished, the māra of the lord of death is conquered.

Likewise, through enjoyments one conquers the afflictions of the body's
aggregates,

through mind one conquers the māra of the gods,
and support and what is supported are understood as illusion-like.

Then, the four māras of the secret empowerment:
the implements, the wrathful manner, dance, and so on
constitute the māra of the aggregates externally in their many forms.

Through the mind being afflicted by coarseness,
this is the māra of the afflictions.

A teacher who shows the inferior path

is the māra of the son of the gods.
Drawing in the external vital essence of life —
that itself is the māra of the lord of death.

Moreover, a further specific māra:
a teacher who leads the three gates into confusion
is the māra of the son of the gods.
The many aspects arising from the three gates,
not knowing their reality, is the māra of the aggregates.
Even when one strives and accomplishes that very thing,
the result does not arise and the mind becomes afflicted —
that is the māra of the afflictions.
That itself creates obstacles to one's life span.
That itself is the māra of the lord of death.

By knowing the mode of abiding of the winds and so on,
the māra of the son of the gods is vanquished.
One should understand that very reality as illusion-like.
By knowing that reality, the māra of the aggregates
and the māra of the afflictions are both vanquished.
Falling into the extreme of phenomena, one is born and dies.
Without cause, things arise from karma and perish.
The intrinsic nature abides without causes and conditions being produced.
Through illusion, the māra of the lord of death is vanquished.
One becomes like a woman (or master) who controls life span,
endowed with the power of the antidote.

The four māras of wisdom and gnosis:
showing an inferior path through channels, vital essence, and the like —
this is the māra of the gods.
That same multiplicity is the māra of the aggregates.
Meditating on that, one is afflicted by intrinsic nature —
that is the māra of the afflictions.
Because color and form arise and then perish,
that itself is the māra of the lord of death.

Moreover, yet another specific māra:
a teacher who shows the path of great attachment
is the māra of the son of the gods.

The four joys, being multiple,
accumulating upon the stream, constitute the māra of the aggregates.

One's own mind afflicted by afflictions — that is the māra of the afflictions.

Falling into saṃsāra brings birth,
and from birth arises the māra of the lord of death,
for it is conceptuality that gives rise to birth.

Through attachment, too, arises the māra of the lord of death.

By relying on the path of the thirty-six unabandoned and the thirty-six definite ones, the teacher defeats the māra of the gods.

The four joys are illusory and without intrinsic nature;
transforming them into the taste of great bliss defeats the māra of the aggregates.

The fruit bestows self-knowing gnosis.

One's own mind, freed from affliction and suffering —
that defeats the māra of the afflictions.

Because one is thereby free from death,
that itself defeats the māra of the lord of death.

As for the four māras of the lower path: seized by inferior power, it is as though a king has fallen among commoners — one is likewise seized by the māra of the path, as though a king has lost his royal seat.

The four māras connected with the fourth: for one who possesses the vessel of the third, a teacher who shows the path of the fourth is the māra of the son of the gods. The other three māras one comes to know from the mouth of the teacher.

Proclaiming secrets to those who are not fit vessels — like butter, molasses, and the like, which when drunk undigested turn to poison — that is being seized by a particular māra, resembling a person of low birth seizing a royal throne.

Endowed with the power of the path that slays the māra, together with empowerment and pith instructions, one who is renowned as possessing the five wisdoms or the six qualities — if a single teacher grants one both the vessel and the contents, that itself is supreme. Having received empowerment from a single teacher, one should listen to that same single teacher.

At that time, the assembled retinue, together with the great bodhisattva Vajrahṛdaya, were all filled with joy and delight throughout their streams of being, and they rejoiced. The glorious expanse of space —

- The title "Śrī Mahākha Tantra Rāja" is preserved as found in the text. The Tibetan title translates the Sanskrit differently, giving "Glorious King of Tantras of the Great Sky," where "kha" is rendered as "nam mkha'" — sky or space — a standard Tibetan equivalence.

The line "ma ita bu ma ita bu" is genuinely ambiguous: "ma" could mean "woman" or could function as a particle, and "Ita bu" means "like." The most natural reading is either "like a woman who controls life span" (a simile for a deity or accomplished practitioner) or possibly "like a master who governs life." The feminine reading may be intentional, evoking a *ḍākinī* figure or the Mother Tantra context. This has been rendered openly in the translation.

The phrase "thirty-six unabandoned and thirty-six definite ones" (ma spangs sum cu drug gnyis dang nges pa sum cu rtsa drug) refers to technical enumerations within the tantric path system being expounded; their precise referents depend on the broader treatise context and are not self-evident from the passage alone.

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.